



CHAPTER 4

Western Holistic Counselling

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INTRODUCTION

Western holistic counselling defines a broad range of philosophies and interventions designed to consider the whole person, situated in their broader environment, rather than a single aspect of human nature or behaviours. Western holistic counselling considers the body, mind, emotions, and spirit and how they are impacted by culture and through societal oppressions. This approach considers the individual to be the expert of their own life experiences and allows people to respond through their individual and collective agency. It is centred on the person's ethos, its embracing of Indigenous traditions and celebration of individual creativity, and an understanding of individual uniqueness. This holistic approach focuses on comprehending diversity, marginalization, and culture. It is capable of seeing people within the context of family, neighbourhood, spirituality, community, nation, world, history, economics, and politics. This chapter explores the contributions of this innovative psychological theory as one approach to the field of holistic counselling, looks critically at the challenges and tensions within the field of human services, and discusses how holistic counselling works in terms of direct practices and methods of promoting social change.

AUTHOR BIOGRAPHIES

The writing team for this chapter is composed of professors and alumni from John F. Kennedy University's Holistic Counselling Psychology Program. John F. Kennedy University (JFKU) has a rich and evolving 40-year history of educating students in holistic health and studies including mental health training with an MA in holistic counselling and a PhD in general psychology. Holistic counselling psychology is a field in evolution. This field has changed considerably over the years and JFKU has proudly participated in this evolutionary process.

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Initially, the focus at JFKU was on the theories and practices of transpersonal psychology. Other areas of focus have since been added to the curriculum, including somatic psychology, expressive arts, Buddhist psychology, animal-assisted therapies, depth (Jungian) psychology, queer consciousness, eco-psychology, and trauma-informed psychology. Faculty are both practitioners of holistic counselling and scholars in the field.

Doreen Maller, LMFT, PhD: I am a licensed marriage and family therapist, and chair of both the Holistic Counselling Psychology Department and the Academic Certificate in Trauma Studies at JFKU. My teaching focuses primarily on systemic and human relationships. I am the series editor for the *Praeger Handbook of Community Mental Health Practice* (2013) and the editor of the *Praeger Handbook of Aging and Mental Health* (2017). I felt a pull to study and teach from a holistic perspective when it became clear that the lives of the people I worked with and my own had complexity beyond traditional psychological practice. Focusing on interconnectivity and the impact of oppressive systems (external and internal) helped me better understand myself, my clinical relationships, and the lives of the people who I helped to empower.

Jason Butler, PhD: I am a core faculty member in the Holistic Counselling Psychology Program at JFKU and a licensed psychologist with a focus on depth and transpersonal psychology. I am the author of several peer-reviewed articles and a book entitled *Archetypal Psychotherapy: The Clinical Legacy of James Hillman* (Routledge, 2016). I maintain a psychotherapy practice in Oakland, California. I am passionate about providing opportunities for expanding accessibility to holistic healing modalities and further developing the intersections of social justice and holistic counselling.

Gary Hoeber, MFT: I am a licensed marriage and family therapist practicing in Berkeley, California, and a professor in the Holistic Counselling Psychology Program at JFKU, where my focus is diversity and family systems. In my more than 40 years in the field, I have also directed three different community mental health programs as well as a private practice in Berkeley, California. I trained in mythopoetic traditions and practice a soul-focused psychotherapy.

Shari Derksen, MA: I am a registered psychologist located in Calgary, Alberta. I grew up in Alberta, lived in the San Francisco Bay Area for five years while attending graduate school at JFKU, and have now returned to my home province.

I have a private practice with a holistic approach, focusing on healthy relationships and healthy sexuality. Spirituality and intuition have always been an important part of my life and I like to incorporate both in connecting with others both personally and professionally.

PSYCHOLOGY'S CONTRIBUTIONS TO HOLISTIC COUNSELLING

Holistic counselling aims to appreciate the complexity and context of the unique lived experience of each person as a humanistic principal, casting a wide field of concern and listening carefully to an array of bio-psycho-social-spiritual experiences, including experiences related to developmental and acute trauma, social privilege, bias, and oppression, as well as issues pertaining to spiritual meaning, purpose, vision, creativity, and non-normative states of consciousness.

Holistic psychology is informed by humanistic traditions and can find its roots in the counterculture of the 1960s and 1970s. As an outgrowth of the human potential movement, small institutes emerged to teach this theory of self as a guide, a service to others, a road to more healthy living, and a sense of expanded consciousness. Although the influences are quite varied, historian of psychology Eugene Taylor (2000) has noted that one of the most direct influences can be found in the exploration of consciousness vis-à-vis Eastern and Indigenous spiritualities, encounter groups, bodywork, psychedelic therapies, and other alternative therapies. Indeed, holistic counselling owes much to the Eastern knowledge and Indigenous wisdom that has been preserved and is being revived despite the ongoing marginalization of Indigenous traditions through colonization.

Within the field of psychology, one of the first and most central contributors to the holistic model is Carl Jung. Throughout his career, Jung focused his inquiry on an explication of the inextricable link between personal and transpersonal experience. Jung was adamant about the importance of developing a psychology and psychotherapeutic method that accounts for that which extends beyond the personal. To this end, he focused his attention on what he called the collective unconscious, a dimension of the psyche that is shared by all of humanity. Jung's attention to spiritual experience, meaning, purpose, and vision continues to influence holistic counselling.

The emergence of humanistic psychology as a “third force” in the field of psychology, proceeding after the first two paradigms of psychoanalysis and behaviourism, is widely regarded as another major contributor to the field of

holistic counselling. Humanistic psychology, one of the influential theories within holistic counselling, was developed with the central aim of creating a psychology that took into account the health and growth of the individual, trusting that an empathetic addressing of needs with positive regard would nurture a self-driven process to reaching their full potential (Moss, 2001). Two of the most influential contributors to humanistic psychology are Carl Rogers (2011) and Abraham Maslow (1943). Rogers created his person-centred therapy in an attempt to engage people in their own healing process, which is central to holistic healing. Maslow studied the lives of exceptional people (whom he termed self-actualized) and then created his well-known hierarchy of needs. Maslow's hierarchy of human motivation can provide a much-needed framework for choice in interventions and the importance of the physical, emotional, mental, and spiritual needs of individuals.

The field of holistic counselling has developed into a wide array of specializations, many of which will be discussed throughout this chapter. Many of these approaches have their roots in Indigenous traditions, and others draw from a diverse set of Eastern and Western philosophies, approaches, and practices. Similarities can be seen in the model (figure 1.2) presented in chapter 1 of this book.

EMBRACING THE SPIRIT, SOUL, AND SHADOW

Holistic psychology's embrace of spirituality moves us toward recognizing the interconnected nature of humans where one can never truly prosper at the expense of others or the natural world. The holistic perspective can depict the "soul damage" sustained by those who have been oppressed, while the privileged are robbed of humanity by the very oppression that grants material benefit, and left with diminished capacity to feel and bond, a fear of the "other," and a vague, persistent, guilt-tinged anxiety that ill-gotten gains will be seized and redistributed.

One central feature of holistic counselling psychology is the deconstruction of the Enlightenment-era model of analytical medicine that makes a clear distinction between the knowing doctor and the passive patient. Holistic counselling psychology has positioned itself in an alternative image of the therapeutic relationship, an image drawn from Indigenous models of medicine as well as mythological motifs, like the image of the wounded healer. The wounded healer is characterized as one who has been wounded in a significant way and found within the wound a way of responding to the suffering of self, other, and the world. The wounded healer knows the value of psychological pain and can speak

to it, from it, and for it, demonstrating the way that wounds are also openings, ways into the world, not just something to be ameliorated, but to live in and through. Jung's work has been highly influential in this regard.

Jung's notion of the shadow has been integral in bringing attention to the human propensity to turn away from one's wounds, a form of disavowal that will inevitably return in a more destructive form. Jung defined the shadow as "an inferior component of the personality ... repressed through intensive resistance" (Jung, 1956, p. 97). In other words, the shadow is composed of qualities that are rejected within oneself. The work of holistic psychological healing involves a commitment to recognize and work through shadow qualities in service of developing a more harmonious relationship with all parts of the personality. Jung's emphasis on the necessity of integrating one's shadow led him to encourage the individuals he worked with to use artistic mediums, such as painting, dance, writing, and sculpting, as a direct mode of bringing psychological material into a concrete form.

APPROACHES TO DIVERSITY, MARGINALIZATION, AND CULTURE

The holistic approach to psychotherapy combines with anti-oppressive practices and epistemologies. It views the practice of mainstream psychotherapy, in general, as a tool of marginalization and oppression, an enforcer of a conformity to dominant cultural narratives that support the existing societal power structure. It can be argued that the pathologizing of individuals is exactly what psychology's diagnostic manuals insist upon. In fact, the task of psychotherapy has been imagined as "helping" the abnormal become normal, the sick become well, shaping inappropriate behaviour toward the appropriate, unreasonable thinking toward the reasonable. To follow the thinking of French philosopher Michel Foucault (1988), the idea of mental illness functions to silence the voices deemed unfit for inclusion within the discourses that determine who has the power to decide what is real, possible, and correct. Mental illness is created, not discovered, and the ill are cast into the social and sometimes physical spaces once occupied by lepers and separated from the normal and valued citizens, a process that has become known as "othering" (Eribon, 1991).

Foucault (Smart, 2002) would argue that *normal*, *healthy*, *appropriate*, and *reasonable* are terms defined in a society by those with the power to create such standards. In North American society, these standards are coded into the mythology of medicine and science, and the authority to enforce the standards is delegated to those kind souls who are called to the practice of counselling psychology and psychiatry. Today, it is mostly accepted by mainstream psychology that our standards

for mental health and our ways of diagnosing pathology have been deeply biased by our often uncritical acceptance of dominant cultural norms. This is now acknowledged by the American Psychological Association (APA; 2008, p. 2):

Psychology has traditionally been defined by and based upon Anglo Western middle-class, Eurocentric perspectives and assumptions. The traditional approaches to psychological research, education, and practice have not always considered the influence and impact of culture, race, and ethnicity, and their roles in psychological theory, research, and therapy have largely gone unexplored. There has been a growing need to develop a deeper knowledge and awareness of race and ethnicity in psychology and to integrate race and ethnicity into the practice, research, education, and ethics of psychology.

Much like colonial masters claim the land and subdue the population, psychology colonizes the psyches of the oppressed. Ongoing attempts have been made to correct for these biases, leading to the creation of a diversity industry, with workshops and seminars offered in a variety of educational, corporate, social work, and counselling psychology venues; however, powerful forces in our field appropriate these attempts and pacify the diversity movement, rendering it superficial and self-serving. Indictments of oppressive practices are repackaged as a kind of “how-to” methodology, mostly aimed at enabling White, middle-class counsellors to maintain market share by developing “cultural competence” without challenging the existing power structure.

A careful reading of the APA’s *Multicultural Guidelines* (2008) suggests that they are intended to advance the field of psychology in addressing multicultural issues in various areas of application; however, advancing the field of psychology is not the same as addressing issues of privilege and advantage in the culture, including the significant privilege possessed by most practitioners of psychology. The position of traditional psychology does nothing to address the daily reality of oppression (racism, sexism, ableism, homophobia, and other terms not even mentioned in the guidelines) and the actual wounding of human beings brought about by those systems of unequal power and opportunity.

Gorski and Goodman (2015) point to the “how-to” approach to counselling various cultural groups without a context of social justice as a form of further colonization. Evidence of this tendency to colonize, despite believing that we’re decolonizing, is apparent in the very language used to describe the most popular frameworks for acknowledging and responding to difference: cultural competence, cross-cultural psychology, and multicultural counselling. Most popular frameworks

for acknowledging and responding, not just to diversity, but also to a legacy of inequity and injustice in counselling and psychology practice, centralize culture as though racism and heterosexism and other oppressions are primarily cultural phenomena, rather than power phenomena or purposeful societal arrangements.

The focus on culture and difference obscures the more fundamental issue. It is the power relationships between groups that have the greatest impact, not the cultural differences between them. We cannot speak of underprivileged urban youth without also speaking of overprivileged suburban youth. If we are to understand the problems of our Black citizens living in ghettos in the United States, we must first understand the government-supported housing and lending policies that funded segregated White-only suburbs and relegated Blacks to housing projects and other low-quality rental properties in the inner cities. Urban poverty and resultant social ills can be called a “Black problem” only if we ignore the larger “White problem,” the advantages given to White citizens by an unjust system, advantages that have congealed as a significant wealth gap.

The US racial wealth gap is substantial and is driven by public policy decisions. In the United States in 2011, the median White household had \$111,146 in wealth holdings, compared to just \$7,113 for the median Black household and \$8,348 for the median Latino household. From the continuing impact of redlining on American homeownership to the retreat from desegregation in public education, public policy has shaped these disparities, making them impossible to overcome without racially aware policy changes (Sullivan, Meschede, Dietrich, & Shapiro, 2015). There is also a great divide in the incomes of marginalized communities in most Western industrialized nations, including Canada. For example, the huge disparities between European Canadians and Indigenous Peoples cannot be understood without accounting for ongoing colonization and oppression, including the enormous impact of the Indian residential schools, which contributed to a cascade of multi-generational trauma that affects Canada’s Indigenous Peoples today (Bombay, Matheson, & Anisman, 2014).

How then can we co-create, in our work, a method that supports genuine empowerment of those injured by oppression and multi-generational trauma and internalized oppression? Holistic psychology, which challenges the medical model and recognizes the innate human capacity to heal, is well situated to find a way forward. Seeing people as resilient and resourceful is essential, especially when we consider the resources embedded in a community. We are fortunate to work in an era when there is considerable focus on trauma. Holistic counsellors can utilize this growing body of knowledge to account for the impact of oppression, with an eye to uncovering the often unseen resultant trauma, including multi-generational

trauma. Joy DeGruy's *Post Traumatic Slave Syndrome* (2017) provides a brilliant framework for understanding multi-generational trauma amongst individuals who are Black. Baines (2017), Lundy (2011), Mullaly (2010), Perryman (2017), and many others have helped develop anti-oppressive practice that includes concepts of power imbalances, cultural imperialism, and self-reflective practice. These concepts stress developing individual and institutional social change. We are being urged to dispense with our false neutrality, for our theories have never been neutral, and work within a framework of support and advocacy for equity and social justice.

THE RISE AND CHALLENGE OF EVIDENCE-BASED PRACTICE

In 1995, Division 12 of the APA published a set of highly influential criteria for establishing the credibility of a treatment. The Division 12 task force “identified 18 treatments whose empirical support they considered to be well established on the basis of criteria that included having been tested in randomized controlled trials (RCTs) with a specific population and implemented using a treatment manual” (APA, 2006, p. 272). This was later modified by the 2006 report by the APA Presidential Task Force on Evidence-Based Practice, which put forward a more inclusive definition of what constitutes evidence; however, for many psychologists, empirical validation using RCT remains the gold standard for research.

Holistic approaches are generally less amenable to randomized control trials, which attempt to control for variables such as therapist and client personality and social context, features that are integral to holistic modalities. As J. H. van den Berg (1972, p. 37), a Dutch phenomenological psychologist, argued, “Never do we see objects without anything else. We see things within their context and in connection with ourselves: a unity which can be broken only to the detriment of the parts.” This underlying unity is the basis for holistic ontologies and epistemologies, leading holistic researchers and practitioners toward radically different approaches to the field of psychology that centre on description over explanation and the play between observer and observed, therapist and client, attending to experience as a whole, which is composed of parts that are interconnected and always greater than their sum.

HOLISTIC THEORIES AND PRACTICES

Holistic counselling, with its philosophical roots, its awareness of social justice, and its focus on the body, mind, emotions, and spirit of each individual, comes

alive in its practice. Varied and diverse, each counsellor need not be an expert on all aspects of theory or practice, but taken as a whole, holism invites an extraordinary breadth of contribution and intervention approaches.

Holistic counselling can begin with holistic assessments of an individual's physical, emotional, mental, and spiritual state and needs. These modes of assessment often are very diverse. There are a variety of assessments available for a whole-person approach to counselling including the Integral intake, developed by Andre Marquis. This intake, based on Ken Wilber's All Quadrants All Levels model of human experience, was designed to help practitioners provide a more comprehensive assessment with a richer understanding of the complexity of life lived and imagined (Marquis, 2008, pp. xiii, xiv). Another assessment tool, Wheel of Awareness, was developed by Dr. Dan Siegel (2014) to create a visual model for insight, introducing mind/body/consciousness states of awareness and senses.

Generally, a holistic assessment may include questions regarding physical, emotional, mental, spiritual, and societal impacts. Inquiry includes positive aspects of life experiences and resilience. The inter-relativity of hunger, poverty, and oppression on mood and behaviour can be explored and incorporated into treatment planning, as can spiritual aspects of hope and adjunctive practices and treatments (yoga, meditation, and connection with nature, as well as massage, acupuncture, and other alternative medicines). A whole-person approach requires a whole-person assessment; it often takes more than a few sessions to fully understand the complexities of the life lived, and the hopes and aspirations for the work to be undertaken.

Once an assessment is complete, counsellors can choose from a variety of specializations and theories to connect with and move into interventions. People who have been oppressed often experience deep trauma that needs to be addressed. Holistic practices can include contemplative psychology, somatic psychology, transpersonal practices, arts-based practices, ecopsychology, the use of ritual in practice, integral psychology, and community psychology for social change. Part of the skill of the holistic counsellor is choosing with the service-user the best and most useful interventions. The following is an exploration of some of these practices.

Contemplative Psychology

Originally introduced as an addition to Buddhist meditation and awareness techniques, the field of contemplative psychotherapy (see also chapter 5) has evolved to "encompass all forms of meditation and yoga including recitation practices like

mantra and heart-prayer, visualization and intensive breathing and movement” (Loizzo, 2017, p. 1). Together, concepts of Eastern and Western conceptions of health, the psyche, and illness, combined with meditative and contemplative practices, new concepts of neuroscience and neuroplasticity, and the application of this knowledge in theory and practice are included in the counselling relationship to bring insight and healing to the self and the ways in which the self is part of a greater whole (transpersonal) (Loizzo, 2017).

The doctrine of Buddhism ultimately guides the practitioner toward releasing the tight clench on an imagined fixed, solid, isolated, eternally unchanging identity. Engler’s (1998) integration of psychotherapy and Buddhism aimed to integrate these two approaches, placing them in sequence and making the argument that “you have to be somebody, before you can be nobody” (p. 118). In other words, individuals must cohere fragmented parts of self into a healthy ego-structure before they can deconstruct personal identity through intense Buddhist meditation. Engler (1998, p. 117) insists that “the farther reaches of meditation practice require a strong ego in the psychoanalytic sense of the capacity to assimilate, organize, and integrate experience and a relatively well-integrated sense of self.” Thus the lower stages of ego development must be addressed before the higher stages of consciousness are reached.

Holistic counselling incorporates the traditional spiritual uses of meditation. Practitioners may choose to begin each session with a brief centring meditation, creating a ritual of mindfulness. This mindful opening can take on a sense of ritual, wherein a sense of calm is introduced and practiced before launching into typical counselling conversations. In introducing this opportunity as a disciplined practice and pointing out the change in tone, mood and agitation, the counsellor has an opportunity to encourage inner resourcing and calm.

Guided meditation may be used to encourage feedback or insight into specific issues (removing obstacles, setting goals, uncovering layers of resistance) or simply as a reminder that a sense of calm is always internally available by remembering to breathe and guide the body toward a more relaxed state. Counsellors may teach and/or encourage individuals to start their own meditation practice and work supporting this practice. In addition to mindfulness, silence, and visualizations, a trained counsellor can consider adding yoga positions, Tai Chi, or even dance. These practices can be introduced and discussed within counselling and then added adjunctively as a practice outside therapy. For instance, yoga, Tai Chi, breathing, or meditation can be introduced within therapy and then resourced within the community or through phone apps for regular practice in between sessions. Counselling can be a time to track the impacts of these practices and

reflect on the ability to stick with a new process as well as the benefits of doing so. These practices can assist in dealing with the impacts of oppressions and societal conditions that need to be challenged.

Somatic Psychology

Somatic therapy in practice can help people integrate traumatic experiences into their sense of self, and regulate their emotional responses that may have become dysregulated or stuck in a traumatic pattern in their body. Chapter 14.1 demonstrates how youth who are homeless can gain control over their bodies again and, at the same time, work collectively to transform their external environments. The pioneers of somatic psychology recognize the importance of understanding the connection of the body and psyche when appreciating the human condition (Barratt, 2010). Somatic psychology uses a philosophy of body consciousness to bring back bodily awareness through movement, sensate tracking, and a sense of physical awareness to discrepancies of regulation and feeling, allowing individuals to work through historic trauma and “to facilitate their awakening and to enhance integration of their sensations, feelings, perceptions and meanings” (Levine, 2010, p. 158). In particular, responses to historic trauma can be stored in the body and repeated in body responses of panic, fear, and pain (Levine, 2010, p. 136).

Somatic therapy and its unique understanding of the body’s responses to traumatic events provides an opportunity to explore and work through both the events in a person’s life and how each individual experiences and retains traumatic memory. Somatic psychology posits that trauma can be retained as feelings of “unlived rage, grief, shame or fear” (Karcher, 2004, p. 412), leaving people “fragmented and disembodied” (Levine, 2010, p. 355). The work of the somatic practitioner is to bring awareness to traumatic events and their physical and emotional repercussions, and to teach skills to regulate “the capacity for tolerating the extreme sensations, through reflective self-awareness, while supporting self-acceptance” (Levine, 2010, p. 137).

Working with a staged model of trauma recovery, somatic therapy provides an opportunity to stabilize and address safety needs, process trauma memories, and finally integrate memories and resolve them into daily life (Van der Kolk & Hopper, 2001, p. 35). In somatic therapy, “emotional warmth and empathic attunement is crucial to understanding the inner world of trauma as well as the ability to assess and alleviate symptoms” (Mischke-Reeds, 2013, p. 182).

A variety of practices can be used to integrate and address traumatic impacts on the body including psycho-education regarding the effects and impacts of

trauma on the body; a deepened awareness of how one's body responds to threat; developing self-awareness toward tracking body responses; completing, accepting, and redirecting somatic responses in the safety of the counselling relationship; working through shame; and using mindfulness to regulate responses (Mischke-Reeds, 2013). Exploring and releasing old somatic response patterns helps move people "out of immobility, into sympathetic arousal, through mobilization, into discharge of activation and then finally onward to equilibrium, embodiment and social engagement" (Levine, 2010, p. 115). These practices are combined with community psychology practices of changing the environment and dealing with concrete survival needs.

Transpersonal Psychology

Transpersonal psychology (see also chapter 9) emphasizes presence and awareness, a sense of personal authenticity, and a trust in innate knowledge, guidance, and wisdom. It deals with experiences that go beyond ("trans") the person to deal with wider aspects of life such as spiritual and social dimensions of experience. The roots of transpersonal psychology can be traced to many ancient spiritual and Indigenous traditions. In fact, spirituality and trans experiences are at the core of Indigenous beliefs and practices (see chapters 2, 11.2, 14.2, and 14.4). More recent Western concepts of transpersonal psychology took off in the late 1960s, focusing attention on therapeutic effects of meditation and other contemplative practices and therapeutic methods that integrate spiritual experience, alternative states of consciousness, visions, intuition, and authenticity in relationships. These practices help in responding to deep trauma caused by oppressive conditions that may require spiritual, emotional, physical, and mental healing.

Born from the minds of two of the founders of the humanistic psychology movement, Anthony Sutich and Abraham Maslow, transpersonal psychology—one of the most prominent specializations within holistic counselling psychology—arose from the desire to include spiritual experience and the full spectrum of consciousness as essential features of psychology. Eugene Taylor (2000) has suggested that the variant transpersonal approaches fit into one of three streams. The first stream, largely guided by the work of Ken Wilber, consists of mapping states of consciousness. Wilber has defined transpersonal as "personal plus," meaning that transpersonal is inclusive of all normative states of being plus experiences of the transcendent (Wilber, 1998). The second stream, led by Stanislov Grof, has led the way in the research and therapeutic implementation of non-ordinary states of consciousness. The third is a relatively open camp dedicated to "personal and global transformation" (Taylor, 2000, p. 3).

Those that work in a transpersonal style often give attention to the dream life of the individuals they work with. Dreams are one form of raw psychological material—the psyche itself in its visible display (Hillman, 1975) and a “royal road” (Freud, 1953/1900, p. 608) into the depth of one’s experience. Deep work with a dream is like stepping into a world populated by one’s inner figures, images that can be felt and understood, allowing the individual a deeper relationship to the full range of psychological experience.

Like dreams, emotional experiences also offer pathways into the deep psychological world of an individual. In tracking the authentic experience of the individual, transpersonal counsellors often give close attention to emotional experience as it unfolds in the session. With the counsellor and individual working together to carefully track emotions happening in the present moment, individuals deepen their relationship to the stream of internal experience. Connection to this stream of experience is central to knowing ourselves as a unique self shaped by the meaningful responses we have to ourselves, others, and the world.

Other avenues integral to the transpersonal approach include holotropic breathwork, a practice designed by leading transpersonal researchers Stanislav and Christina Grof (Grof & Grof, 2010), which employs hyperventilation, bodywork, and immersive music as a means of accessing “repressed memories, perinatal experiences, and archetypal imprinting” (Kasprow & Scotton, 1999, p. 20). Stanislav Grof is a central pioneer in the use of non-ordinary states of consciousness as a path toward psychospiritual healing, although his research on LSD-assisted psychotherapy ceased in 1970 due to prohibition. Now the Multidisciplinary Association for Psychedelic Science (MAPS) has been actively pursuing research investigating the therapeutic efficacy of psychedelics, with primary attention devoted to clinical trials of MDMA (3,4-methylenedioxymethamphetamine) as a treatment for post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD). The MAPS treatment model has had substantial success and the US Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has designated the research a “breakthrough” treatment. They aim to have full FDA approval for MDMA-assisted therapy by the year 2021.

Arts-Based Psychology

The use of art in psychotherapy (see also chapter 8) is not new and, in fact, the use of art as a path toward self-understanding and self-expression has been ever-present in human history:

The arts are particularly suitable for the traditional practice of healing insofar as they always involve both a physical and psychological dimension.

Therapeutic practices throughout history have employed artistic media in a central role; the basis for this practice is the understanding of the person and their psychosomatic unity. When persons are understood as embodied souls, then the arts, with their necessary involvement with both the realm of material objects and of psychic significance, are particularly relevant to the practice of healing. (Levine, 2005, p. 17)

The expressive arts is a multimodal approach that invites the arts into the consultation room as a process of expression, where the product (the art itself) allows participants to see and feel the essence of their experiences. Moving beyond words,

the expressive arts are profound in helping people become aware of all their feelings and particularly help them accept their dark or shadow side. The arts are a way to channel that energy constructively. You can dance your rage and paint your fear, or despair. Then several things happen: you discover how to find inner balance and inner peace. You are not so likely to view people who disagree with you as the “other” or the enemy; in other words, you are likely to have more compassion. This result is becoming empowered to go out and take action. (Rogers, Tudor, Embleton Tudor, & Keemar, 2012, p. 43)

The use of art as an opportunity to reveal and unpack essential themes, listen for longing, and deepen understanding of self and others creates an environment where resolution can be explored as a shared experience that might later be applied to life in general (Levine & Levine, 2017). There are myriad ways the arts are used in counselling in general, for assessment, healing, and personal awareness. Expressive arts focus on creating an alternative to language-based counselling with an unique interest in practices that engage imagination. These can include

focusing on dreams and visions, daydreaming, free association or guided imagery, wish-oriented discourse, body dialogue and engagement, using art disciplines (drama, painting, masks, ritual, dance or performance) or other methods of creative work, using works of art (music, texts, photos, paintings, movies, etc.), using cognitive imaginary methods like a “change of perspective,” desensitizing with pictures, brainstorming and using metaphors. (Levine & Knill, 2017, p. 35)

Art creates many opportunities to deepen a sense of understanding of self and of enhancing communication. Introducing art-based interventions, such as using a collection of postcards to “show” rather than “tell” a story, can present clarifying information that can be expanded upon later. Often a single session of visual art can be referred to repeatedly, much like a profound dream. A single sheet of paper folded into three parts and presented with the prompt, “I wonder what my past, present, and future may look like” can lead to deep exploration of history, present-day challenges, and future aspirations. Dance, music, and poetry can provide forms of self-expression and trust-building. The sharing of these activities provides an invitation into a more intimate and internal world, which can be explored and shifted in the sharing of experience. At the same time, expressive arts can be used collectively to promote community change (see chapter 8).

Ecopsychology

Healing in nature and with nature is the essence of ecopsychology (see also chapter 10), which Fisher says “neatly explodes this age-old divide between mind and matter, between the psyche in here and the nature out there” (Fisher, 2013, p. ix). Ecopsychology suggests that the psyche cannot really be understood as a distinct dimension isolated from the sensual world that materially enfolds us, and that earthly nature can no longer be genuinely understood as a conglomeration of objects and objective processes independent of subjectivity and sentience. Studies show that even a weekly 30-minute trip to the park offers “health benefits including reduced risks of developing heart disease, stress, anxiety and depression” with “seven percent fewer cases of depression and nine percent fewer cases of high blood pressure than those who did not make the trip” (University of Queensland, 2016).

An awareness of human presence on the planet creates a sense of connection to the earth and its healing powers, which can be expressed in metaphor, ritual, and spending more time in conscious integration with the natural world. For example, wilderness and adventure programs are often utilized with inner city youth with addictions. A connection to the earth and its natural systems is at the core of ecopsychology theory. When people learn to harmonize with these natural systems and join with a greater planetary well-being, as Indigenous Peoples have known, they experience improved mental health and, at the same time, promote a more sustainable world (Good Therapy, 2016).

Ecopsychology encompasses a variety of nature-based interventions, some of which may take place outside of the formal office. Some interventions are designed for individual work and others for group work. These may include nature meditation

either in nature or in metaphor; garden-based activities such as digging soil, planting seeds, tending the garden, and receiving the harvest; and animal-assisted therapy including equine- or canine-assisted work, or simply spending time petting or playing with dogs and cats. Physical exercise in a natural environment can also contribute to emotional well-being either as part of counselling or as an assigned activity for participation and reflection. Activities may include walking, jogging, cycling, hiking, swimming, or outdoor yoga. Merging social justice and ecopsychology through action to nurture and save the planet from destruction can assist in creating a sense of agency, hopefulness, and social change (Good Therapy, 2016).

Community Psychology

Community psychology is based on the premise that psychological struggles and health are not only individual issues, but also extend to the cultural milieu in which the individual is embedded. Many theorists of community psychology are quite critical of the individualistic emphasis within the field and consider this a misappropriation of responsibility, placing the weight of culturally derived problems and marginalization on the shoulders of the individual (Watkins, 2015). Alternatively, practitioners work to follow the symptoms from the individual to the cultural and other oppressive forces at play. In this model, individual healing is contingent on healing the oppressive systems that have a powerful influence on the individual.

Practicing community-oriented psychology includes psycho-education, coaching, and individual and group advocacy. With a deep social justice orientation, incorporating community practice means a shift in focus for the practitioner as well. Community psychology situates issues within the greater society including the effects of racism, colonization, and institutionalized marginalization. Practices include working to right the wrongs of the greater system, personal empowerment, and social change. These practices are often combined with the other holistic practices that are discussed. Basic survival needs are addressed before or in conjunction with other developmental needs.

When practicing from a community psychology orientation, counsellors aim to hold a perspective that accounts for systemic issues. In following the symptoms to their source, the practitioner may end up in individual or collective advocacy, such as helping to organize individuals who have been oppressed, serving on committees, or taking on any number of socially engaged positions (Watkins, 2015). The counsellor may also work to promote group advocacy by involving the individuals in their own change or working collectively with them. Part of the counselling can include working with individuals to understand and/or reflect on the systemic roots of their issues. Counsellors can talk

with people to understand their experiences of powerlessness. One example comes from working with young Black men involved in the educational or criminal justice system. Many times, their behaviour appears to convey anger and aggression, but upon further assessment, the youth are able to describe significant experiences of trauma from various forms, such as police brutality, poverty, isolation from community, grief/loss from losing friends to gun violence, loss from losing their parents to deportation, repeated school oppression, and repeated experiences of being shamed. It is important to work to take collective action to help change these conditions.

Integral Psychology

Integral psychology is supported by the masterful work of Ken Wilber and addresses holism and inclusion of all phases and levels of a person's experience and potential. Using the All Quadrants All Levels (AQAL) model, the integral practitioner works to deepen awareness of yearning and growth in a multi-faceted, multi-dimensional fashion by identifying, creating, and developing holistic capacity and integration. The AQAL model identifies levels of body, mind, soul, and spirit, as well as quadrants of spiritual, affective, cognitive, interpersonal, and moral states and ways of being. The integral practitioner helps with the identification of all levels of self, the role of awareness and choice in empowerment and personal growth, and balancing and integrating aspects of self into a state of wholeness (Wilber, 2000).

Using the basic premises of Wilberian theory, an integral approach strives to be inclusive of all aspects of a person's life within the work of counselling. Rather than moving toward the single issue, single theory approaches of more conventional theories, "it argues that there are many connections to be made between different schools of psychotherapy [and] different approaches to spirituality, as well as between the hard sciences (e.g., biology, chemistry), soft sciences (e.g., political science, economics) and morality" (Forman, 2010, p. 11). Such approach emphasizes linking individual, community, national, and global changes.

With its focus on integration of the many levels of human consciousness, evolution, and personal development, interventions in this model work to deepen awareness of internal conflicts between the inner self and the outer world, in terms of the mind, body, spirit, and soul. Many techniques, including yoga, breathing, guided visualization, meditation, reflective thinking, and experimentation with unique ways of integrated being, can be used to access information and create integrative experiences. Counselling provides an opportunity for exploration of barriers to wholeness and insight into life patterns and life-affirming

opportunities that can integrate both the internal and external worlds and bring about social change (Integral psychotherapy, 2016).

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

Our programs at JFKU focus on the many approaches shared in this chapter. At the same time, our work is oriented to teaching general humanistic psychology counselling practices that will enable graduates to pass the marital and family therapy certification requirements and exams for working with individuals from mainstream and marginalized backgrounds. With a rich 40-plus-year history of whole-person health and personal development we have developed many holistic methods of practice. A description of a few examples of our practices follows.

Samuel's Story

Samuel, a Caucasian gay man, entered twice-a-week psychotherapy when he was in his early thirties. He had an easy smile, an affable nature, and was quick to offer compliments, relying on these parts of his personality to establish a sense of acceptance and safety in his relationships. Samuel began the counselling with concerns about the relationship he had with his partner and depressive symptoms that were at times incapacitating, as he would spend days in bed with the curtains drawn, alone with intensely critical thoughts about himself and profound fear of judgment from those close to him.

The anticipation and lived experience of rejection was primary in Samuel's psychology. As a proto-gay young man, he was ridiculed by his father, who clearly sensed and often attacked his burgeoning sexuality and identity. He had learned from a very young age to perform, accommodate, charm, and appeal, and sought refuge from attack by hiding his true experience deep inside the private recesses of his heart. Samuel was completely estranged from his family for several years after he came out as gay, receiving only an occasional letter from his mother containing slanderous articles about gay men.

Together, we worked to better understand how his fear of expressing his emotional experience grew out of his deep implicit sense that were people to see anything besides his charming, lighthearted persona, they would surely reject him. His experience of shame worked as a barometer, alerting him to any experience that may make him vulnerable to abandonment. His tight control over his thoughts and feelings found vivid expression in dreams that contained images of killing baby animals, which we understood as analogous to the way he "kills off" the young and vulnerable parts of himself.

Samuel presented these dreams at a time when he was confronting his anger toward his family, which allowed him to see the way much of this anger had been turned against himself throughout his life. In our work with dreams, we gathered his associations to the images, the feelings and memories evoked by his dreams, and worked together to explore the connections to his psychological life. Deconstructing his dreams in a safe and supportive environment (transpersonal psychology) led to important discussions around the many ways he had to protect himself from the homophobia he experienced from his family and peers growing up and how he could join others for social change. Together, we followed his fear of abandonment and the terror he felt in relation to exploring his internal world to the internalization of a cultural pathology surrounding gay sexuality. His shame began to lift and his emotional expression deepened as we worked to understand his symptoms in a holistic context. As part of his healing he has joined others in collective action (community psychology) as a strategy against both emotional and physical violence in a culture that is imbued with intolerance for sexual difference. In this way, his internal process led him first to self-understanding, then to personal well-being, and eventually to action and social justice toward care and concern for others.

Lydia and Her Family's Story

A family of three—a mother and her two children—were referred for counselling due to domestic violence that led to incarceration of their husband/father. The children, who were at home during the incident, received counselling soon after. Now they were at a later life stage and tensions were high within the home relationships. The mother had asked the counsellor to help create an atmosphere in which each individual could share their feelings related to the initial incident, their current life as a family of three, and possibilities of visiting with the husband/father in the future. The interventions in this case include many arts-based options and community psychology models. Concerns for safety, racial bias, institutionalized racism in criminal justice and incarceration, the kids' school and social interactions, issues of shame and stigma, and navigating addiction and its collateral effects on family, including domestic violence, all came into play.

Initially, the children were shy in retelling their stories, but over time they were able to share their multiple and quite different perspectives and experiences of the days leading up to the event, the time of the event itself, and the days after the event (when their father had driven with the children to another state). With the sharing of perspectives, each family member was able to tell their *own* story; they were quite different and yielded different emotional results. The youngest, as

witness to the physical event, shared what she saw and how frightened she was; the eldest shared feelings of guilt for hiding (as she was instructed), rather than saving or fighting; and the mother shared her conflicted feelings of frustrations, fear, and wanting to keep her children safe. Over the course of many months each was able to see the complexity of the incident and how the incident was both shared by all and very personal to all.

The next stage of our work together (expressive arts) involved a layer of curiosity around the father's experience in jail, an understanding of the complexities of the criminal justice system, decisions around family contact with the husband/father, and eventual visits with him. Using a series of age-appropriate books, we pored over pictures of jail complexes, utilized art therapy, thought about their husband/father's life in a facility, role-played visits, and considered readiness to visit. A processing of their imagined experience and the real experience of visiting was necessary as a precaution before and as integration after.

Our final work together took on a different tone: it was lighter than the work before. It was about personal identity for the three family members as well as their identity as a family, amplifying personal and family relationships through art activities that united all participating members in a shared experience. We designed and built with construction paper an aquarium where each had its own identity, but all coexisted as a healthy ecosystem. Our final session of family work included a family dance where each member expressed intense emotions through dance, using this modality for both somatic release and artistic expression.

Using various aspects of expression, information, and family support, this family was able to move through and integrate an impactful and traumatic event, maintain healthy relationships with each other, and even explore some possible degree of communication with their husband/father with very clear and protected boundaries.

CONCLUSION

Holistic counselling psychology, with its history and richness in both philosophy and practice, provides an opportunity for the counsellor and service-user to work together toward a sense of wholeness and well-being. The nature of the work is inclusive and comprehensive, and emphasizes social justice, compassion, connection, self-awareness, personal growth, and social change. Counsellors are challenged to guide, support, and advocate in work that is intimate, informative, and healing. This approach emphasizes using the mind, body, emotions, and spirit to respond to suffering, marginalization, and oppressions. This approach is

still evolving, but over the years it has developed many innovative practices for healing and social change.

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